

Ontological Vertigo

The Apprehension of Asymmetric Dependence

A patristic, Thomistic, and mystical study

From the First Mover and received existence
to creaturely consent and the God who is love

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1 The Prior beneath the Question

A fact can be known for years and then change its weight. One has always known, in some loose sense, that one did not cause one's own birth. The sharper recognition is present-tense: *I do not originate or sustain the act by which I exist now*. My existence is genuinely mine, but it is not from me.

Beneath ordinary thought lies a tacit prior. Existence is treated as the possession already in hand before the question of gift or dependence begins. I may admit causes of my body, education, or circumstances while imagining an independent possessor underneath them all. Ontological dependence reaches beneath that picture. It concerns not first what helps an already existing thing to flourish, but what accounts for there being an actual thing with powers that can flourish at all.

The word *vertigo* is metaphorical. Nothing must spin, and no feeling proves a metaphysical conclusion. The term names what may happen when a judgment becomes reflexive: the inquirer discovers that he has never occupied a position outside the dependence he is considering. The familiar self remains solidly real, yet loses the imagined status of being self-grounded.

Governing thesis

Ontological vertigo is the reflexive apprehension of asymmetric dependence: the intellectual arrest in which a creature recognizes that it is wholly real and genuinely active, yet neither originates nor sustains the act by which it exists, while the uncreated source depends upon it in no corresponding ontological way.

The terms name different moments. *Dependence* is the ontological fact; *asymmetry* is its irreversible form; *apprehension* is the intellect's judgment; and *arrest* is the interruption that occurs when the judgment includes the knower. Recoil and consent are possible responses to that arrest. Neither response supplies a premise to the argument.

The governing sentence is this article's synthesis; the realities it gathers are inherited. They have appeared under a long succession of terms: participation, act and potency, creation from nothing, conservation, received existence, primary and secondary causality, humility, adoration, and contemplative unknowing. Their history matters because each term protects the apprehension from a different distortion.

2 Act and the First Mover

Christian metaphysics did not begin with an empty vocabulary. Plato and Aristotle supplied questions and distinctions that later thinkers would receive, criticize, and transform.

In the *Republic*, Plato places the Good beyond the objects whose truth and being it makes intelligible (VI, 508e–509b). In the *Timaeus*, whatever comes to be requires a cause, and the ordered cosmos points toward a maker looking to an intelligible model (27d–29b). These texts establish a vertical grammar: what appears does not contain the whole account of its intelligibility or actuality. Yet Plato's Good is not simply the God of Christian doctrine, and the *Timaeus* does not state creation from nothing.

Aristotle makes the decisive distinction between potency and act. Change is the actualization of what is potential; what is only potential cannot, in the same respect, actualize itself. In *Metaphysics* XII.6–7, the order of motion therefore requires an eternal actuality that moves without being moved. Heaven and nature depend upon a first principle. Aristotle's eternal cosmos, celestial movers, and emphasis on final causality are not yet Aquinas's free universal Creator, but the question has acquired its durable form: can derivative actuality be its own sufficient source?

Aquinas gives the argument its most compact Christian statement in the First Way (ST I, q. 2, a. 3). Whatever passes from potency to act is actualized by what is already actual in the relevant respect. If an actualizer is itself being actualized here and now, its power to actualize is derivative. A here-and-now order composed only of such derivative actualizers would never possess the underived actuality through which any member acts. Aquinas therefore concludes to a first mover not moved by another.

"First" does not mean merely earliest. The argument does not depend upon a first measurable instant, and Aquinas elsewhere denies that natural reason demonstrates a temporal beginning of the world (ST I, q. 46, a. 2). Nor is the First Mover a first domino whose work is finished once later motions begin. The priority is explanatory: intermediaries act only insofar as they possess or receive actuality.

The conclusion at this stage is deliberately limited. The First Way does not by itself state the full doctrines of free creation, providence, or Trinity. Aquinas reaches divine simplicity, goodness, intellect, will, and universal causality through further arguments. That cumulative movement must be respected; otherwise a genuine ascent is replaced by a name attached too quickly to its first terminus.

3 The Fathers: Life That Does Not Arise from Us

3.1 Begun and continued by another

Irenaeus gives an early, unusually direct account. Against the claim that a soul must be unbegotten in order to endure, he distinguishes God, who alone is without beginning, from everything made. Created things begin and continue as long as God wills them to exist. The soul is not life itself but participates in life bestowed by God; “life does not arise from us” (*Against Heresies* II.34.2–4). His immediate subject is the soul’s duration, not a later scholastic theory of *esse*. Still, the asymmetry is plain: continuance is conferred; the giver does not receive continuance from the recipient.

Athanasius sharpens the Creator–creature distinction against both spontaneous origin and formation from coeternal matter. God makes the universe from nothing through the Word and grants existence from goodness (*On the Incarnation* 3). In *Against the Heathen* 40–42, the Word also orders and preserves the created whole. Human beings are mutable creatures; incorruption is not native to humanity but a gift. Athanasius’s language of corruption and return toward non-being also serves his account of sin and redemption, so it should not be flattened into a single metaphysical formula. Its governing judgment remains: the Word is not one fragile participant among others. He is the divine giver through whom creatures are called into being and held in order.

3.2 More inward than the self

Augustine turns the same dependence inward. At the opening of the *Confessions* he asks how he could exist unless God were in him, then corrects the direction: rather, unless he were in God (I.2.2). He later calls God more inward than his inmost self and higher than his highest part (III.6.11). This is not pantheism. In Book VII he rejects the thought that God is a spatial substance spread through the world, then apprehends the immutable Light above his mutable mind (VII.1.1–2; 10.16–11.17). Divine transcendence and divine intimacy intensify together: the cause of being is not a part enclosed within the creature, yet no created cause is present at a deeper explanatory level.

Dependence is no longer only a proposition about the cosmos. The inquirer discovers it within the act of inquiry. Augustine’s changeable mind judges mutable things by unchangeable truth (*Confessions* VII.17.23); the life by which it seeks God is already upheld. Augustine describes the encounter with both trembling and love. The response is not evidence added to a weak argument. It is what can occur when the argument’s object is apprehended as the present condition of the knower’s own existence.

The Fathers establish the Christian field Aquinas will later articulate more exactly: one uncreated God, creatures called from nothing, the Word as creator rather than creature, created duration as gift, and a divine presence that does not dissolve the distinction between giver and recipient. The First is no longer only the terminus of motion. He is the free giver of a world that neither supplies his perfection nor completes his life.

4 The Thomistic Center: A Relation with Weight on One Side

4.1 Existence received under a limit

Aquinas’s account of received existence is not simply the First Way repeated in different words. The First Way begins from change and concludes to an unmoved mover. The argument from participated being asks a wider question: why does anything whose actuality is limited to a received mode exist at all? The two lines converge, but neither should be collapsed into the other.

A finite thing has an essence: a definite way of being this kind of thing rather than another. But knowing what a human, oak, or angel is does not yet show that such a thing exists. That epistemic difference is not itself the

demonstration. Aquinas further argues that whatever possesses existence without being existence itself receives it from another; creatures possess caused existence according to a limited nature (ST I, q. 3, a. 4; q. 44, a. 1; *De ente et essentia*, ch. 4).

The first universal cause cannot receive the actuality it ultimately explains. Aquinas therefore identifies God not as one being with an unusually secure possession of existence, but as subsistent being itself, *ipsum esse subsistens*. This is a Thomistic conclusion, not a definition imposed on every Catholic school. Its force here is precise: creatures have being by participation; God does not participate in a more basic actuality. If the proposed first cause received existence, the explanation would not yet have reached the source of participated being.

4.2 Creation as a real relation in the creature

Aquinas makes the asymmetry explicit in the language of relation. Creation, considered passively, places in the creature a real relation to the Creator as the principle of its being (ST I, q. 45, a. 3). The creature's very condition is *from another*. In God, however, creation adds no accident, perfection, or change. The divine act is identical with the simple divine being; the new term is the creature.

His earlier treatment of divine names states the pattern with still greater clarity. God is outside the whole order of creation; creatures are really ordered to him, not he to them in the same ontological order (ST I, q. 13, a. 7). Aquinas accordingly calls the relation creature-to-God real and the corresponding relation in God a relation of reason.

"Of reason" does not mean fictional. God really knows, wills, creates, preserves, and loves creatures. The phrase denies that creation installs in God a dependent feature by which God becomes more actual. The name "Creator" is newly true when creatures exist, but no intrinsic divine alteration has occurred. The ontological weight lies on one side: the creature is constituted as an effect; God is not constituted as God by producing it.

4.3 Conservation is not an ancient event

Creation in Aquinas's strict usage names the total origin of a creature's being without presupposed matter or subject; it does not by itself imply temporal newness. Present dependence is treated directly under conservation. An agent may cause only a thing's becoming, as a builder builds a house that afterward stands through the properties of its materials. The universal cause of being is different. Every creature depends on God precisely for being, and therefore cannot subsist apart from the divine conserving action (ST I, q. 104, a. 1).

Aquinas uses light in air as an analogy. Air is genuinely illuminated, but its light does not become self-rooted through duration; it remains dependent on the illuminating source. The comparison has limits—God is not a physical emitter and conservation is not a sequence of repairs. Aquinas says that the conserving action continues the action by which God gives existence, without motion or time (q. 104, a. 1, ad 4). The counterfactual "without this action the creature would not be" states an explanatory dependence. It does not picture an intermittent God deciding from moment to moment whether to resume.

The conclusion is substantive, not true by definition. An objector may treat finite existence as a brute fact or claim that, once produced, it persists without a cause of its being. Aquinas answers that the universal cause gives the act of being that no creature possesses by essence (q. 104, a. 1). This paper adopts that Thomistic account; the possible feeling of vertigo supplies no missing premise and does not make disagreement irrational.

The thesis can now be stated without metaphor. Every creature receives and is presently conserved in the act by which it exists; the first cause receives its act from neither the creature nor another. The dependence is therefore ontological and asymmetric. Its apprehension becomes arrest only when the universal proposition turns: *I am one of the recipients it describes*.

5 Dependence without Rivalry

Total dependence sounds, at first, as though it must leave the creature with nothing to do. That conclusion follows only if divine and created causes compete on the same plane, like two hands trying to move one lever. Aquinas denies the premise.

God gives creatures not only existence but definite natures and powers. Fire heats, parents generate, physicians heal, intellects understand, and wills choose. When God works in every agent, the agent's proper operation is not suppressed; it is grounded (ST I, q. 105, a. 5). Even conservation can employ ordered created causes while God remains the principal cause (q. 104, a. 2). The creature is not less real because its dependence is more radical. It can act in its own right precisely because the Creator causes it to be the kind of cause it is.

The point extends to freedom. God moves voluntary causes according to their voluntary mode rather than by converting willing into compulsion (ST I, q. 83, a. 1, ad 3; I-II, q. 10, a. 4). Divine causality does not occupy a portion of the will's agency and leave the remainder to the creature. The whole act may be from God as first cause and from the person as a responsible secondary cause, in different orders.

This distinction protects both metaphysics and empirical inquiry. A biochemical account of metabolism, a neurological account of perception, and a historical account of a decision can each be true at its own level. Divine causality is not inserted where an empirical explanation fails. It concerns the actual existence and operation of every cause that empirical inquiry succeeds in identifying.

Six confusions excluded

- *Not deism*: the Creator is not merely a remote starter; creatures are presently conserved.
- *Not occasionalism*: created causes possess and exercise real powers.
- *Not pantheism*: dependence does not make creatures parts, modes, or pieces of the divine substance.
- *Not chronology alone*: even a hypothetically beginningless creature would depend for being.
- *Not coercion*: primary causality can cause a voluntary act to be voluntary rather than replace it with force.
- *Not quietism*: consent to creaturehood is not passivity before injustice, error, or any particular evil.

The *Catechism* joins the two sides without embarrassment. God upholds creatures “at every moment” and enables them to act (CCC 301); he also grants them the dignity of being causes and principles for one another (CCC 306–308). The same doctrine that denies creaturely aseity establishes creaturely agency.

This supplies the first reason not to remain in recoil. Recoil interprets dependence as invasion: the greater the divine causality, the less room for the creature. But the source of a creature's actuality does not arrive to displace an already self-grounded created agent. No such creature has ever existed. What is displaced is only the imagined claim to aseity; the creature itself, with its proper powers, is established.

Non-rivalry does not yet establish the whole language of trust or love. It does establish that ontological dependence is not, by its nature, humiliation. To deny self-origination is not to deny the self.

6 The Fork: Recoil or Consent

The metaphysical judgment and the spiritual reception of it must be distinguished. A contemplative experience cannot repair an invalid inference, and no particular sensation is promised to one who understands the argument. Yet patristic and mystical writers describe the interval in which a truth already known becomes difficult to hold at a distance.

6.1 Arrest before response

Augustine gives that interval an exact form. In *On the Trinity* VIII.2.3, he asks the reader to attend to Truth itself. The mind receives something like a first flash, cannot sustain the gaze, and slips back into familiar earthly images. His subject there is not a proof of present conservation. His phenomenology is nevertheless apt: intellectual contact precedes the retreat by which the mind recovers its accustomed standpoint.

The *Confessions* makes the response more personal. Before the immutable Light Augustine knows himself as made (VII.10.16), and later knows his changeable mind as judging mutable things by unchangeable truth (VII.17.23); before eternal Wisdom he both shudders and burns, *inhorresco et inardesco* (XI.9.11). Trembling is not yet refusal. Disproportion may be felt at the same moment that likeness awakens desire. *Recoil*, in the stricter sense used here, is the movement that interprets the disproportion as a reason to withdraw.

A terse taxonomy

Apprehension	The intellect judges asymmetric dependence to be true.
Arrest	The judgment turns upon the knower: <i>this is true of me</i> .
Recoil	The self withdraws as though dependence threatened its reality.
Abasement	The self relinquishes false elevation and takes its creaturely place.
Consent	The will freely agrees with the truth of creaturehood.
Humility	That truth becomes a stable disposition.
Magnanimity	Received goods are accepted as real powers to be exercised.
Self-forgetfulness	Attention ceases to make the self its own measure.
Adoration	The whole person renders God the reverence due to the first principle.

These are distinctions, not a guaranteed sequence of feelings or a ladder of mystical states. Dependence is true before consent; consent changes the person's relation to the truth, not the truth's ontological force.

6.2 Proper abasement

Aquinas prevents humility from becoming self-contempt by pairing it with magnanimity. A difficult good both attracts and occasions retreat. Humility restrains the appetite from reaching beyond right reason; magnanimity strengthens it against despair and urges it toward genuinely great goods according to right reason. The virtues are compatible because both preserve truth (ST II-II, q. 161, a. 1, especially ad 3; q. 129, a. 3, ad 4).

This pairing is decisive. Pride converts received good into an occasion for inordinate self-exaltation, sometimes treating it as though it came from oneself. False abasement denies that a good was given. Humility confesses, *I am not from myself*; magnanimity adds, *what I have received is truly mine to exercise*. Neither sentence survives without the other.

Aquinas's account of adoration makes the bodily language of abasement exact. Interior adoration is devotion and reverence; kneeling or prostration signifies that inward act. In prostration, he says, "we profess that we are nothing of ourselves" (ST II-II, q. 84, a. 2, ad 2). The claim is not *I am nothing*. It is *I am, but not from myself*. Devotion, the ready will to give oneself to divine service, supplies the volitional center of consent (q. 82, a. 1).

The *Catechism* draws the same consequence. Adoration acknowledges God as Creator and "infinite and merciful Love"; it confesses the creature who would not exist but for God, yet sets the worshiper free from turning in upon himself (CCC 2096–2097). C. S. Lewis makes the attentional point in modern terms: genuine humility ends habitual self-occupation (*Mere Christianity*, III.8). Proper abasement therefore begins with self-knowledge and ends by ceasing to make the self the horizon.

6.3 The mystics: little, real, and loved

Julian of Norwich holds littleness and goodness together. In chapters 5–6 of the long text of her *Revelations of Divine Love*, the created whole appears as a tiny thing, about the size of a hazelnut. It lasts because God loves it: made, loved, and kept. Beholding the Maker makes the soul seem less in its own sight, but the result is reverent dread, true meekness, and charity rather than disgust with creaturehood. The image does no independent work as a proof. Its force is to make received being apprehensible at once.

Yet universal dependence is not sanctifying union. In *Ascent of Mount Carmel* II.5.3–7, John of the Cross distinguishes God's substantial presence, by which every creature is preserved in being, from transformative union by likeness of love. A sinner does not cease to depend ontologically on God; a saint does not cease to be a creature when united to him.

Pseudo-Dionysius then names love's movement beyond self-enclosure. In *Divine Names* IV.13–14, love is ecstatic: it carries the lover toward the beloved and returns toward the Good from which it proceeds. This is not annihilation of the created person. It is the redirection of attention and will away from self-possession as a final end.

Bernard of Clairvaux supplies the free answer. In *Sermons on the Song of Songs* 83.3–6, the soul is conformed to the

Word through the will, loving because it has been loved. Its return is whole but never equal—*etsi non ex aequo*. The lover is not Love itself; the thirsty one is not the fountain. Yet love may be wholly the creature's act while continually received from its source.

7 At Reason's Shore

The recognition of present dependence did not disappear when medieval vocabulary ceased to govern philosophy. In the Third Meditation, Descartes argues that past existence does not by itself account for present existence. Preservation and creation differ only conceptually in the respect under discussion: a cause is required not only for the self's production but for its conservation now. His method and metaphysics differ sharply from Aquinas's, but the present tense of dependence survives.

The Catholic doctrinal boundary was stated with particular force by Vatican I. *Dei Filius* confesses a God really and essentially distinct from the world, freely creating not to acquire or increase divine beatitude but to manifest perfection through goods bestowed upon creatures (ch. 1). When the constitution turns to faith, it says that the human person wholly depends upon God as Creator and Lord (ch. 3). The council defines the Creator-creature distinction and the freedom of creation; it does not canonize every Thomistic explanation used here.

Within Aquinas's own cumulative argument, the First Mover is not left as an unnamed source of motion. Subsequent questions treat the first principle as free of potency and composition, subsistent being, supreme good, intelligent, and willing (ST I, qq. 3, 6, 14, 19). Because the divine goodness is already complete, creatures are not willed as though God needed them in order to become perfect. They proceed from will, not from a necessity imposed by deficiency (q. 19, aa. 3–4; q. 44, a. 4).

Aquinas can therefore speak of divine love without reducing it to a passion. To love is to will good to another. Human love is awakened by a goodness it encounters; God's will causes the being and goodness that it loves. God loves every existing thing, Aquinas argues, because every actuality and perfection exists through the divine will (q. 20, aa. 1–2). Natural theology can accordingly reach a true, analogical judgment: the uncreated source freely wills the good of creatures.

It cannot, by that judgment alone, penetrate the inner life of God. Gregory Nazianzen permits knowledge that God is from the order of effects while denying comprehension of what the divine nature is (*Oration* 28.3–6). Pseudo-Dionysius likewise lets causal affirmation pass through negation and eminence: the source is not contained within the creaturely mode of any predicate (*Divine Names* V; *Mystical Theology* I). Aquinas expressly denies that the Trinity can be demonstrated by natural reason (ST I, q. 32, a. 1).

Here the distinction between discovery and revelation becomes decisive. Metaphysics can discover that the first source lacks nothing, gives being freely, and wills the good of what exists. Revelation alone discloses the Trinitarian depth of that giving. The exact confession occurs in the First Letter of John: "God is love" (1 John 4:8, 16). Its context defines the words by the sending of the Son for the life of sinners and by the charity to which the beloved are called (4:7–21). The phrase is not the inversion *love is God*; God's self-disclosure governs what love means.

John also says that perfect love casts out fear (4:18). This does not abolish wonder, creaturely reverence, or Augustine's simultaneous trembling and desire. It casts out servility—the stance that relates to God chiefly under fear of punishment. Aquinas distinguishes that servility, which charity removes, from fear of punishment itself, which may remain but diminishes as charity grows; filial fear—the fear of offending or being separated from the beloved—grows with charity (ST II–II, q. 19, a. 10).

The *Catechism* gathers the movement. The God who creates from wisdom and love acts freely, not from need (CCC 293–295); the God whose "very being is love" eternally communicates the life of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit and destines creatures to share in it (CCC 221, 257). Love does not cancel ontological asymmetry. It reveals why asymmetry need not be interpreted as rivalry.

8 The Argument Finds the Reader

Every creature receives and is conserved in being. Its nature and actions are genuinely its own. The first cause neither receives actuality from those actions nor acquires perfection by producing them. The dependence is present, total in

the order of being, noncompetitive, and asymmetric.

But the knower has not stood outside that statement for a single moment. The act by which he follows the argument is itself among the received acts the argument describes. The conclusion is not merely before him. It includes him.

I am.

I am not from myself.

Existence is not added to a self already there. There is no more original self behind received being to which the mind can retreat.

To say *I am not from myself* is not to retract *I am*. It is to understand it. Recoil would protect not the creature but the fiction that the creature first possessed itself and was afterward subjected to God. Proper abasement relinquishes that fiction. Consent does not create the dependence; it freely agrees to it. Humility makes that agreement stable. Magnanimity accepts the good given. Adoration turns the freed attention toward God.

Press the asymmetry further. God does not become more perfect by creating. The world fills no absence in him. I do not complete God. If the first source required the creature in order to possess his perfection, dependence would finally run both ways.

It does not.

Yet I am.

No creature possesses a prior claim to existence. Creaturely being is freely bestowed.

What is neither compelled by lack nor owed by justice is gift. For Aquinas, to love is to will the good of another; in God, that willing does not discover a goodness already there but causes it. Reason can therefore say more than *I am caused*. It can say: *I am because God wills that I be* (ST I, q. 20, aa. 1–2).

Divine non-need is therefore not divine indifference. The creature supplies no missing good, answers no deficiency, and completes no unfinished life in God. Nevertheless, God freely wills created good. The loss of imagined aseity need not end in recoil. The self that does not complete God is nevertheless willed by God.

Reason can now reach a precise conclusion, and a precise limit. *God loves* and *God is love* are not the same proposition. The first can be known analogically from God's free willing and causing of created good. The second names the inner life of God. It is not the conclusion of the First Way, nor of the argument from participated being.

Revelation does not repair a defective proof or supply an omitted premise. It discloses the giver whom reason has reached without comprehending. The Father sends the Son so that sinners may live. Love begins not in the creature's return but in God: "he first loved us" (1 John 4:9–10, 19).

The asymmetry remains entire. The creature's answer is received and unequal, yet it can be whole.

I give God nothing he lacks. The One whom nothing completes gives himself.

God is love.

A Scope, Method, and Qualifications

A.1 Reader, question, and method

This is a discursive metaphysical and spiritual-theological article for a serious general reader. It asks what the phrase “ontological vertigo is the reflexive apprehension of asymmetric dependence” can mean within a Catholic and specifically Thomistic account of creation, how related judgments have appeared across the centuries, and what distinguishes recoil from a fitting creaturely response.

The governing phrase and its taxonomy are project synthesis, not received technical definitions. “Apprehension” means an intellectual judgment; “arrest” means the interruption when that judgment is grasped as true of the knower; “recoil” and “consent” name possible responses. No affect proves the judgment or indicates sanctity, infused contemplation, private revelation, or a state of grace. The conclusion’s increasingly spare form is literary enactment, not an additional premise.

Source class	Function in the article	Governing boundary
Ancient philosophy	Supplies participation, ontological priority, potency and act, and unmoved actuality.	Plato and Aristotle are neither made implicit Christians nor credited with creation from nothing or Thomistic conservation.
Sacred Scripture	Governs creation through the Word and the revealed confession that God is love.	Biblical revelation supplies no omitted premise in the First Way; “God is love” retains its Christological and ethical context.
Conciliar and catechetical teaching	Governs one free Creator, real distinction from the world, total creaturely dependence, genuine secondary causality, adoration, and Trinitarian love.	Dogmatic and authoritative boundaries do not canonize every Thomistic step in the article.
Patristic witness	Supplies creation from nothing, continuance by divine will, divine intimacy, intellectual arrest, and apophatic restraint.	Later terms are not retroactively placed in a Father’s text; breadth is not an authority count.
Thomistic theology	Provides the principal account of the First Way, participated existence, relation, conservation, noncompetitive causality, humility, magnanimity, adoration, divine justice, and divine love.	The claims form a cumulative argument; school metaphysics and philosophical conclusions remain distinct from revealed Trinity.
Mystical witness	Shows dependence received in trembling, littleness, love, self-forgetfulness, and union without absorption.	Images and experiences illustrate response; they do not substitute for demonstration or promise a reproducible feeling.
Later Christian witness	Preserves present conservation and describes humility’s freedom from self-preoccupation.	Descartes and Lewis are used narrowly; neither governs the paper’s metaphysics or authority structure.
Project synthesis	Defines ontological vertigo, arrest, recoil, consent, abasement, and self-forgetfulness and orders the final movement from knowledge through poetic compression to love.	The taxonomy and final formulations belong to this article, not to a cited source.

A.2 Included and excluded scope

Included are selected ancient antecedents; representative patristic accounts in Irenaeus, Athanasius, Augustine, Gregory Nazianzen, and Pseudo-Dionysius; Aquinas on the First Way, participated existence, creation, conservation, relation, secondary causality, humility, magnanimity, adoration, divine justice, and divine love; mystical reception in Julian of Norwich, John of the Cross, and Bernard of Clairvaux; Descartes on present conservation; Lewis on self-forgetful humility; and doctrinal boundaries in Vatican I, the *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, and 1 John 4.

Excluded are a comprehensive history of metaphysics; a defense of every premise against every contemporary objection; the Kalam argument and physical cosmology; a complete account of providence, evil, grace, deification, Trinitarian processions, mystical prayer, or theodicy; and adjudication among Thomist, Scotist, Suárezian, Palamite, or contemporary analytic accounts of dependence. The conclusion is not a composed prayer. No legal, jurisdictional, or mutable disciplinary conclusion is made.

A.3 Material qualifications

1. The definition describes the article's adopted Thomistic conclusion; it is not itself a demonstration. Brute-fact and "existential inertia" objections remain substantive disagreements about causal explanation.
2. The First Way concludes to a first unmoved mover. Divine simplicity, subsistent being, universal free creation, providence, and love require Aquinas's further arguments; Trinity and the full Johannine confession require revelation.
3. "First" names explanatory priority, not necessarily the earliest moment. Aquinas denies that natural reason demonstrates a temporal beginning of the world (ST I, q. 46, a. 2).
4. The asymmetry is limited to the order of created being. It does not deny that God truly knows, wills, loves, addresses, and covenants with creatures.
5. Aquinas's claim that the creature has a real relation to God while the corresponding relation in God is one of reason denies a received accident or perfection in God; it does not make divine action imaginary.
6. Essence and existence are metaphysical principles, not two objects or substances. Their real distinction in creatures and *ipsum esse subsistens* are the article's adopted Thomistic articulation.
7. Participation in being does not make a creature a fragment, mode, or material part of God. Creator and creature remain really and essentially distinct.
8. Creation, conservation, and concurrence are distinguished: total origin without presupposed matter; persistence in received being; and divine action in the operations of real secondary causes.
9. Present dependence is not repeated temporal re-creation. God's eternal act produces and conserves temporal effects without change in God.
10. Dependence in being is not identical with corruptibility or modal contingency. Even an incorruptible creature, or one necessary through another, possesses being from another (ST I, q. 44, a. 1, ad 2).
11. Primary causality does not reduce created causality or freedom to appearance. The whole effect can be from God and from a creature in different causal orders.
12. Consent means willing agreement with creaturely truth; it does not make dependence true, constitute supernatural faith, excuse passivity before evil, or erase responsible secondary agency.
13. Humility and magnanimity are complementary virtues. "Nothing from oneself" means non-aseity, not worthlessness, total corruption, or denial of received natural and supernatural goods.
14. An initial shudder is not treated as culpable refusal. Recoil names withdrawal grounded in an interpretation of dependence as threat; filial reverence remains compatible with charity.
15. Creation is neither compelled by a lack in God nor antecedently owed by justice to a recipient not yet existing. God nevertheless acts according to divine wisdom and will and, within the created order he establishes, gives each nature what belongs to its condition (ST I, q. 21, a. 1, especially ad 2–3; a. 4, ad 4).
16. Divine love is predicated analogically. "God is love" does not mean that a creaturely abstraction called love is God, nor does philosophical knowledge demonstrate the Trinity (ST I, q. 13, a. 5; q. 32, a. 1).

17. Divine concurrence with a sinful act does not make God the author of the defect constituting sin: God causes the act's actuality, not its defective mode (ST I-II, q. 79, a. 2).
18. Pseudo-Dionysius is identified as an anonymous late-fifth- or early-sixth-century Christian author, not as the convert of Acts 17. Mystical union by grace is distinct from the sustaining divine presence common to all creatures; neither is identity of essence.

A.4 Translations, rights, currentness, and review

Scriptural language is limited to short traditional or working-English phrases. Patristic and mystical checking used the identified public-domain ANF, NPNF, Parker, Warrack, Eales, and Lewis–Zimmerman witnesses, together with stable work and locus citations. Thomas is cited by work, question, article, chapter, and reply; governing Latin loci were checked in the Corpus Thomisticum where identified, with public English used as a working aid. Descartes is cited by the Third Meditation.

The focused paraphrase of C. S. Lewis's *Mere Christianity*, III.8, reproduces no Lewis wording. The popular sentence “humility is not thinking less of yourself, but thinking of yourself less” is not attributed to Lewis because the C. S. Lewis Foundation identifies it as a common misattribution. Scripture, official texts, translations, and all other source wording remain outside the project's CC BY 4.0 grant. The surrounding synthesis is project-created.

Online witnesses were checked through 20 July 2026. The publication is an internally source-audited working study. It has not received independent philosophical, patristic, Thomistic, mystical-theological, dogmatic, literary, or ecclesiastical review and claims no ecclesiastical approval.

B References

Scripture and authoritative Catholic witnesses

- Sacred Scripture: Wis 11:24–26; John 1:1–3; Acts 17:24–28; Rom 11:36; Col 1:16–17; Heb 1:3; 1 John 4:7–21, especially vv. 8, 9–10, 16, and 18–19. Short English wording is used as a working rendering; Scripture and translations retain their own status. The exact phrase “God is love” is from the First Letter of John, not the Gospel; working English witness.
- First Vatican Council, dogmatic constitution *Dei Filius* (24 April 1870), chs. 1 and 3 and canons 1.3–5: the simple God really distinct from the world, free creation from nothing, divine non-need, providence, and the creature's total dependence; official Latin.
- *Catechism of the Catholic Church* 218–221 and 257 (God's very being and Trinitarian life as love); 285, 290–301 and 306–308 (free creation, transcendence, sustaining action, and secondary causality); 2095–2097 and 2628 (adoration, creaturely dependence, humility, and confident love); divine truth and love, Trinitarian purpose, creation and conservation, and adoration.

Ancient philosophical antecedents

- Plato, *Republic* VI, 508e–509b, on the Good as source of intelligibility and being; *Timaeus* 27d–29b, on becoming, cause, and the cosmic craftsman. Benjamin Jowett's public-domain English was used as a working witness at the Internet Classics Archive and Timaeus text. The article does not identify these doctrines with Christian creation.
- Aristotle, *Metaphysics* XII.6–7, 1071b3–1072b30, on actuality, the unmoved mover, and the dependence of heaven and nature; W. D. Ross's public-domain working English, Internet Classics Archive. See also *Physics* VIII.5–6.

Patristic and late-patristic witnesses

- St. Irenaeus of Lyons, *Against Heresies* II.34.2–4, on God alone unbegun, created duration according to divine will, and life by participation; Alexander Roberts and William Rambaut's 1885 ANF working English, online witness.
- St. Athanasius of Alexandria, *On the Incarnation of the Word* 3–5, on creation from nothing through the Word and creaturely mutability, NPNF working English; *Against the Heathen* 40–42, on the Word ordering and preserving the created whole, working English.
- St. Augustine of Hippo, *Confessions* I.2.2; III.6.11; VII.1.1–2, 10.16–11.17, and 17.23; XI.4.6–9.11, on existence through divine presence, inwardness and transcendence, the changeable mind's judgment by unchangeable truth, creation in the Word, and *inhorresco et inardesco*; *On the Trinity* VIII.2.3, on the mind's first flash of Truth and return to familiar images. Public-domain NPNF working English: *Confessions* VII, *Confessions* XI, and *On the Trinity* VIII.

- St. Gregory Nazianzen, *Oration* 28.3–6, on the failed attempt to grasp God directly and on knowing God’s existence from created order while failing to comprehend the divine nature; NPNF working English.
- Pseudo-Dionysius, *Divine Names* IV.9 and 13–14, on recollection, ecstatic love, and return to the Good; V.1–8, on the superessential cause from whom beings receive existence; *Mystical Theology* I.1–3, on affirmation, negation, and unknowing. John Parker, trans., *The Works of Dionysius the Areopagite*, vol. 1 (London: James Parker, 1897), public-domain working edition.

Thomistic framework

- St. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 2, a. 3 (the First Way); q. 3, a. 4, q. 4, a. 2, q. 6, aa. 1–2, q. 13, a. 5, q. 14, aa. 1 and 8, and q. 19, aa. 1, 3–4 (subsistent being, goodness, analogy, intellect, free will, and willing creatures without need); q. 20, aa. 1–2 (divine love and its causation of created goodness); q. 21, a. 1, especially ad 2–3, and a. 4, ad 4 (divine justice, derivative created dues, and creation without an antecedent creaturely claim); q. 32, a. 1 (Trinity not demonstrable by natural reason).
- Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 13, a. 7 (Creator–creature relational asymmetry); q. 44, aa. 1 and 4, q. 45, aa. 1–3, 5, and q. 46, a. 2 (participated being, creation, its finality, and the temporal-beginning limit); q. 83, a. 1, ad 3, q. 104, aa. 1–2, and q. 105, aa. 4–5 (freedom, conservation, and secondary causes); I–II, q. 10, a. 4 and q. 79, a. 2 (divine motion without coercion and the defect of sin); II–II, q. 19, a. 10, q. 81, aa. 1–2, q. 82, a. 1, q. 84, aa. 1–2, q. 129, a. 3, ad 4, and q. 161, aa. 1–5 (fear, religion, devotion, adoration, magnanimity, and humility).
- Aquinas, *De ente et essentia*, ch. 4, on created essence and existence and the first cause whose essence is existence; *De potentia*, q. 3, a. 7 and q. 5, a. 1; *Summa contra Gentiles* II.15–21 and III.65–70, for creation, conservation, and secondary causes.
- Latin loci checked in the Corpus Thomisticum Leonine-text corpus; the New Advent Summa was used as a working public English index. Work, question, article, chapter, and reply control over either site’s wording.

Mystical and later witnesses

- St. Bernard of Clairvaux, *Sermons on the Song of Songs* 83.3–6, on voluntary conformity, the creature’s unequal yet whole return of love, and love’s continual reception from its source; Latin checked in *Sancti Bernardi Opera*, vol. 2, 300–302, with a stable online Latin witness; Samuel J. Eales’s 1895 English used only as a public-domain aid.
- Julian of Norwich, *Revelations of Divine Love*, long text, chs. 5–6, on the created whole as made, loved, and kept and on littleness issuing in reverent dread, meekness, and charity. Grace Warrack’s 1901 public-domain working English, CCEL edition; the image is treated as mystical apprehension, not demonstration.
- St. John of the Cross, *Ascent of Mount Carmel* II.5.3–7, distinguishing God’s sustaining substantial presence in every creature from transformative union by love and preserving the natural distinction between creature and Creator. David Lewis, trans., Benedict Zimmerman, rev., *The Ascent of Mount Carmel* (London: Thomas Baker, 1906), public-domain working edition, Internet Archive scan.
- René Descartes, *Meditations on First Philosophy*, Third Meditation, on present conservation and the conceptual distinction between preservation and creation in the respect argued; public-domain Elizabeth S. Haldane translation, online witness.
- C. S. Lewis, *Mere Christianity*, III.8, “The Great Sin,” on genuine humility as freedom from self-occupation. The point is paraphrased; no Lewis wording is reproduced. The common aphorism about “thinking of yourself less” is not attributed to Lewis; see the C. S. Lewis Foundation attribution record.

C Generation Metadata

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